

ROYA
PUBLICATION

No. 22

FICTION

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LES FOLIES • I

FOLIE DOUCE

by Chew Z

A Roya Publication

BOOK ONE OF THREE

FOLIE DOUCE

— the gentle madness —

CHEW Z

ROYA PUBLICATION

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FOLIE DOUCE
A Roya Publication — No. 22

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, institutions, places and incidents are the products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, to actual agencies, or to actual events is entirely coincidental.

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Synopsis

Martin Coyle sits at Window 9 of a benefits office in Bellhaven, a rain-coloured city where four hundred thousand decent people attend perfectly to the person in front of them and to nobody else at all. He has four minutes to give each of sixty-two claimants a day. It has never been enough, and it never will be, and this is not anybody's fault.

On a Tuesday in April he is eleven minutes late to a hearing four and a half miles away. Nothing improper occurs. The traffic is within normal range. The roadworks are properly noticed. The switchboard functions as designed. A continuance is entered, fourteen weeks are assigned, and somebody has to find a form of words for a six-year-old who has been told her father is coming.

Two days later a woman named Dalia Reyes comes to his window with a four-character error on a form, and Coyle discovers, with the mildness of a weather report, that the world contains no mechanism whatsoever requiring him to hurry.

What follows is conducted entirely within the rules. Nothing is refused. No voice is raised. Every act is defensible in writing.

Folie Douce is a slow account of a man who set out to prove that one bad day can reduce the sanest person alive to lunacy, and who was patient enough, and reasonable enough, and courteous enough to find out.

A Note from the Author

This book has no drug in it.

Every other volume in this series has turned on some substance or practice that alters what a person is able to perceive — something swallowed, sung, endured, or whirled into. This one is about the absence of one. Attention is the only compound I know of that everybody dispenses, all day, without training or licence, in doses too small to notice and with effects that outlast us.

I have been interested for a long time in a particular kind of harm that has no author. Not cruelty — cruelty is easy to write and easier to condemn, and it flatters the reader, because the reader is never the cruel one. I mean the other thing. The harm that arrives through a correctly functioning system staffed entirely by decent, overextended people, each of whom is doing the right thing with the resources available, and the sum of whose right actions is a life coming apart on the other side of a pane of glass.

Nobody signs that. There is no name at the bottom of it. And because there is no name, the person it happens to cannot be angry at anyone, and cannot appeal, and cannot even describe it convincingly — which is the part I could not stop thinking about, and which became this book. Suffering is not a signal. It does not transmit. There is no organ in a city for detecting it.

The Joker of a certain graphic novel argued that all it takes is one bad day. I have always found that idea seductive and always suspected it of being a lie — not because it is too dark, but because it is far too flattering. One bad day makes a man a casualty, and a casualty has dignity, and an event is a thing that happens *to* you.

What actually unmakes people is slower and much more ordinary than that, and it does not arrive as an event at all. It arrives as an interval. It arrives as a queue that clears at eleven to fourteen a day.

Martin Coyle is not a monster and I have taken some care to make sure of it. He is a competent man behind a window with four minutes to give and sixty-two people to give them to, and the arithmetic he does every morning is arithmetic I have done, and so have you. If he is anything, he is early.

I would like to say that the reader is safely outside this. I do not think that is true. Somewhere today a person is going to ask you for something small, and you will have an excellent reason, and the reason will be true.

That is where the horror lives. Not in the bad day. In the excellent reason.

— Chew Z

Contents

PART ONE — THE SLOW MAN

One · AE Day 99	8
Two · BE Day 2 — 9:41	12
Three · AE Day 1	14
Four · AE Day 6	19
Five · AE Day 14	23

PART TWO — COMPOUNDING

Six · AE Day 23	28
Seven · BE Day 2 — the drive	32
Eight · AE Day 31	35
Nine · AE Day 40	38
Ten · BE Day 16	41

PART THREE — ACEDIA

Eleven · AE Day 58	46
Twelve · AE Day 63	50
Thirteen · BE Day 2 — 9:41 to the end of it	55
Fourteen · AE Day 70	61
Fifteen · AE Day 77	65

PART FOUR — WATER

Sixteen · AE Day 91	70
Seventeen · AE Day 98	75

PART ONE — THE SLOW MAN

ONE

AE Day 99

Every calendar is somebody's confession.

Consider the ones you use without thinking. Somewhere behind them is a man who decided that a particular morning mattered more than all the mornings before it, and that everything prior should be counted backward from that point, receding, diminishing, like streetlights in a mirror. He did not discover the zero. He set it. And then he told everyone, and after a while nobody remembered it had ever been otherwise, and the whole species went on living inside one man's opinion about which day had been important.

I set mine in March. I am not embarrassed about this.

The convention I use is simple, and I will explain it once so that you are not confused later. Everything before is BE. Everything after is AE. The experiment concluded on a Wednesday evening at approximately nine o'clock, on AE Day 98, and the Thursday that followed it is AE Day 99, and that Thursday is where I am now, at 6:12 in the morning, sitting on the edge of my bed with my shoes already on, looking at the wall.

I put my shoes on before I was fully awake. I do not remember doing it. This is not alarming. A man who has done a thing four thousand seven hundred times will do it in his sleep, and I have gone to work four thousand seven hundred times, and I will go today, because the line will begin forming at six-forty whether I am standing behind the glass or not.

The room is a rented room on Ansel Row with one window and a radiator under it. Rain came in the night and it is still coming, that

thin persistent Bellhaven rain that never commits to falling and never stops, the kind that does not soak you so much as it gradually agrees with you. Through the glass the street is the color of a nickel left in a puddle. A bus goes past below with its interior lights on and the windows fogged, and inside it a dozen faces are turned toward nothing, wiped soft by the condensation, and none of them look up, and there is no reason on earth why they should.

This is the part where I am supposed to tell you what the experiment was.

I am not going to do that yet, and I want to be honest about why: not because I am ashamed of it, but because if I tell you now you will have an opinion about it, and the opinion will arrive before the evidence, and then you will spend the rest of this reading the evidence backward, looking for the places where it supports what you already decided. Everybody does that. It is the single most reliable thing about people. It is more reliable than kindness, more reliable than self-interest, more reliable than fear.

So instead I will tell you the finding, which is the part that matters, and you can do what you like with it.

The finding is that it takes one bad day.

Not one bad life. Not a defect present at birth, waiting in the blood like a debt. One day. One arrangement of ordinary, defensible, entirely legal events, occurring in the correct order, to a man who has done nothing wrong and who is at that moment as sane as you are — and by nightfall he is somewhere else, and he will never come back, and nobody who watched it happen will be able to name a single moment when anything improper occurred.

That is the whole thesis. It fits on a card.

I want to be clear that I did not invent this idea. Men have been saying it in bars for a century. What I did was test it, which nobody does, because testing it requires a subject and a controlled environment and a certain willingness to be patient, and because the people who like the idea are generally not the people who own the necessary apparatus.

I own the apparatus. I want to be clear about that too. I did not build it, I did not choose it, and it was not designed for this. It was designed to help people, and it does, most of the time, at a rate I could look up if you wanted the number.

Downstairs the front door of the building opens and shuts, and someone coughs in the stairwell, and does not stop coughing, and goes out into the rain still coughing, and that is the entire interaction I will have with my neighbors this week.

I stand up. I straighten the bed. I count the four dark squares of the window as the light comes up behind them — one, two, three, four — and I do not know why I do that, and I have done it since I was a child, and it is not important.

At the corner of Ansel and Vessel there is a man asleep in the doorway of a shuttered pharmacy with his hand out, palm up, in the rain, and the palm has filled with water. Nine people pass him while I wait for the light. I counted. I always count. Not one of them looks, and I want to say something here that I think is misunderstood: *not one of them is doing anything wrong*. They are late. They have their own arrangements. Their attention is a finite substance and it has already been spent, this morning, before eight o'clock, on things that also deserved it.

Attention is the only currency that cannot be borrowed against. You cannot take out a loan on it. You cannot save it. You get some

number of minutes of it per day and when it is gone it is gone, and everyone you fail to spend it on will experience your poverty as cruelty, and they will be wrong.

I crossed with the light. I did not look either.

That is not a confession. That is the control condition.

• • •

TWO

BE Day 2 – 9:41

The corridor is on the fourth floor of the Vessel Street courthouse, in the district everyone who works there calls the Ossuary, because the files go in and they do not come out, and because it is faced in a pale grey stone that sweats in the summer.

The corridor is thirty-one feet long. There is a bench along the left wall, oak, worn pale in two places where people have sat for a very long time. There is a window at the far end with wire mesh in the glass, and the mesh divides the sky over Bellhaven into ninety-six small grey diamonds. There is a door on the right marked **410** with a paper sign taped beneath the number, and the paper has yellowed, and the tape has been replaced more recently than the paper.

Behind the door a woman's voice is reading numbers. Not words. Numbers — a docket being called, matters being taken up in their order, and each number is a family, and the voice gives each one about four seconds.

There is a clock above the door. It is the kind of clock they put in institutions, white face, black hands, a red sweep for the seconds that moves in small deliberate jerks, and it says 9:41.

I am standing at the near end of the corridor with rain still on my shoulders and my coat over my arm and my breath going hard, because I ran the last two blocks and then I ran up four flights because the elevator was doing what elevators do in a building of that age, and I have a folder in my hand with everything in it. Everything. Four months of it. The certificates from the classes. The signed sheets from the supervised visits, twelve of them, each one

initialed by a woman with a clipboard. A letter from a supervisor. A letter from a landlord. The receipts.

The clerk's window is a rectangle cut in the wall beside the door, with a shelf, and a small brass grille set into the glass so that sound can pass through but nothing else can. Behind it a young man is looking at a screen. He is perhaps twenty-six. He is not doing anything wrong.

I say my name. I say the matter number. I say it twice because the first time it comes out with no air behind it.

He looks at the screen and then he looks at me and his face does the thing that faces do, the small softening, the flicker of a person recognizing that another person is about to be hurt and that they themselves are going to be the instrument of it and that there is no way around this and it is not their fault. It is a look I know very well. I make it at work. I make it eleven times a day.

He says: *That matter was called at nine-thirty.*

The red sweep hand goes around once while neither of us says anything.

Down the corridor the wire mesh divides the sky into ninety-six diamonds and I count them. I get to ninety-six. Then I count them again, because I have to do something with the next four seconds, and there is nothing else in that corridor to do them with.

• • •

THREE

AE Day 1

She came to my window on a Thursday in the second week of April, two days after the corridor, and that Thursday is AE Day 1 — though I did not know it at the time, because the calendar had not been invented yet and neither had I.

I should describe the office, because you will be spending a good deal of time in it and because the room does most of the work in what follows. If you take nothing else, take the room.

Bellhaven District Four, Office of Benefit Determination, second floor of a municipal building on Kelder Street that was put up in 1931 as a savings bank and has never fully stopped being one. Marble floor worn into a shallow trough down the middle where a hundred and seventy thousand people a year walk the same line. High windows that face north, so the light is grey by nature, and no lamp anyone has ever installed has fixed that. A ceiling of pressed tin panels, painted over so many times the pattern has gone soft, like a face under a sheet.

There are eleven service windows. I sit at Window 9.

The windows are glass, floor to ceiling, with a brass grille at mouth height and a steel tray beneath it for documents. The glass was put in during the eighties after an incident nobody will describe to you in detail. It is thick enough that voices come through flattened, stripped of their low end, so that everything anyone says to me arrives sounding slightly reasonable, slightly further away than the person saying it. I have worked behind that glass for nineteen years. I no longer hear the flattening. I hear the world as it is delivered to me, and I have to remind myself, sometimes, that outside the glass

people's voices have a bottom to them.

The queue begins forming at six-forty in the morning. We open at eight-thirty. On a bad Monday the line goes down the marble stairs and out the doors and along Kelder in the weather, and the people at the back of it will not be seen that day, and they know this by about ten o'clock, and they stand there anyway, because leaving is worse.

Here is the arithmetic, and I want you to have it, because everything after this is arithmetic.

I see, on average, sixty-two people in a working day. The day is four hundred and eighty minutes long, of which perhaps four hundred are usable once you subtract the parts of a human being that cannot be scheduled. Four hundred divided by sixty-two is six and a half. Six and a half minutes per person, and out of that must come the greeting, the identification, the retrieval of the file, the reading of the file, the explanation, the entry, and the goodbye.

Realistically you have four minutes of attention to give any human being who comes to that window. Four. And then you have to take it back, all of it, and put it on the next one, and if you fail to take it back the line does not move and everyone behind them pays for your generosity.

That is not a policy. Nobody wrote it. It emerges, the way weather emerges, out of a number of people and a number of minutes.

Her name was Dalia Reyes and she was thirty-four years old and her problem was a code.

Not a crime, not a hardship claim, not a hearing. A code. A field on a form, four characters long, which had been entered as one thing when it should have been another, and which had caused a

determination to issue in a category that did not apply to her, and which therefore had to be corrected before anything else in her life could proceed. It is the most common problem I see. It is a typing error with a shadow.

I liked her immediately, which is worth recording. She came to the window with her folder already open to the correct page, which almost nobody does, and she had highlighted the field, and she said good morning, and she waited for me to say it back before she started, which is a courtesy so rare in that building that I noticed it the way you notice a bird indoors.

I gave her four minutes. I gave her the whole four. I found the error, and I explained what the error was, and I explained that the correction could not be made at my window because the field was owned by another unit, and that what I could do was route it, and that once routed it would be reviewed, and that the review would issue a corrected determination, and that the corrected determination would restore the category.

She asked how long.

I said ordinarily eight to ten working days.

And she said thank you, and she meant it, and she put her folder back together in the careful way of a person who has learned that documents are the only part of her situation she can control, and she left, and the marble took her footsteps and gave them back doubled, and I looked down at the routing field.

Here is the moment, and I have been very careful with it, because I have gone back to it many times since and I want to give it to you exactly as it happened and not as it became.

The routing field takes a unit code. There were two units that could plausibly own a correction of that type. One of them would handle it in eight days. The other would handle it in eight days as well, but would first determine that it did not belong to them, and would return it, and the return would take between three and five weeks, and at the end of those weeks the file would arrive back on my desk having lost nothing except time, with no error committed by anyone, and with a full and defensible record.

Either code was correct. That is the part I need you to understand before you go any further. *Either code was correct.* An auditor examining that field a year later would find nothing to remark on. There is no version of this in which I did something.

I sat with my hand on the keyboard for what I estimate was nine seconds.

I would like to tell you that I thought about it. That there was some argument in me, some weighing, a devil at one ear. There wasn't. What there was, was a small grey flatness, a total absence of urgency, the feeling you get looking at a glass of water when you are not thirsty.

I thought: *I don't have to hurry.*

That was all. That was the entire content of the thought. Not *I will hurt her*, not *I will test her*, not one word of the philosophy I later built over the top of it like a roof over a hole. Just the discovery, arriving with the mildness of a weather report, that the world contained no mechanism whatsoever that would require me to be quick.

I typed the second code. I hit enter. The screen cleared and put up the next matter, and I said "next, please," and a man in a wet parka sat down and started telling me about his hours, and I gave him his

four minutes, and I did not think about her again until Tuesday.

The thesis came later. Weeks later. I assembled it the way you assemble anything after the fact, out of the materials lying around, and when it was finished it was very good, and it explained everything, and it fit the evidence perfectly, which is what should have worried me.

You do not build a roof and then discover a hole. It goes the other way. It always goes the other way.

FOUR

AE Day 6

She came back on the following Tuesday because the corrected determination had not arrived, and she was apologetic about coming back, which is the thing I remember most clearly from that second visit.

People apologize to me constantly. They apologize for their handwriting, for the state of their documents, for not understanding a sentence that was written specifically to not be understood, for crying, for the smell of the rain on them, for existing in the eleventh position of a line of sixty. In nineteen years I have never once been able to work out where they learned it. Nobody teaches you to apologize for needing a thing you are entitled to. It arrives on its own, the way the counting arrived in me, out of some earlier room.

She said: "I'm sorry, I know it's only been six days, you said eight to ten. I just — if it comes at ten days I can still make the fifteenth, and if it comes after that I can't, so I thought if I checked now and something was wrong there'd be time to fix it."

That is a well-constructed sentence. I want to note that. She had thought about the shape of the problem before she opened her mouth, she had identified the deadline, she had reasoned backward from it, and she had arrived at my window with a proposal rather than a complaint. Out of sixty-two people that day she was the only one who did that.

I pulled the file.

The screen told me what I already knew: that the matter had been routed to a unit which would, in the fullness of time, determine that

it was not theirs. There was a status line. The status line said **IN REVIEW**, which was true. It is always true. It is true of a file that is being read by a woman at that exact moment, and it is true of a file that has been sitting in a plastic tray in a room on the fourth floor since the Nixon administration. **IN REVIEW** is one of the great sentences of our language. It means: *somewhere, in principle, a person exists who could look at this.*

I said: "It's in review."

She leaned toward the grille. "Is that good?"

And I did a thing I want to describe precisely, because it is the whole method, and because if you are waiting for the part where I lie to her you will wait until the last page.

I said: "It's normal."

That is true. It was entirely normal. It was, in fact, the most normal thing in that building. Approximately a fifth of everything in the Bellhaven benefits system at any given moment is sitting in a unit that will eventually decide it does not belong to them, and this is not a scandal, it is a consequence of having eleven units and a form with one routing field. I did not invent it. I only declined to correct for it.

She said: "Okay. Okay, good."

She was relieved. I watched relief happen to her face through an inch of glass that took the bottom out of her voice, and I felt nothing, and I want to be exact about the nothing: it was not coldness. Coldness is a temperature and implies a fire somewhere else in the house. This was more like a room with the furniture taken out.

Then she started to talk.

They do that, when they are relieved. The fear goes out and the words come in to fill the space, and for about forty seconds you get the actual person instead of the case. She told me she worked at a laundry service on the Draw, six to two, and that her brother lived with her, and that the fifteenth was a redetermination date for something else entirely, some other office, some other window, some other man, and that everything in her life was a chain of dates each of which depended on the one before it.

She said: "It's all one thing. That's what nobody — it's all one thing, and everybody I talk to only has the one piece of it."

That is the most accurate description of the system I have ever heard, and it came from someone standing on the wrong side of the glass, and she was not trying to be clever. She was trying to be understood, which is a different project entirely, and a worse-paying one.

I said: "I understand."

I said it because it is what you say. It is the closing phrase, it is how you signal that the four minutes are up, it is a sound with the shape of a kindness in it. It costs nothing and it works.

Above her head the ceiling of that hall runs in pressed tin panels, sixteen inches to a side, in rows. From Window 9 you can see eleven rows across and, if you lean, nineteen deep, and the ones near the north windows have gone the color of weak tea from eighty years of light.

Eleven times nineteen is two hundred and nine.

I counted them while she talked, the way another man might look at his hands, and when she stopped talking I said the true thing about the review, and she thanked me twice, and she went out through the

doors into the rain on Kelder Street.

Two hundred and nine. There is a panel over the third window that is not tin at all but a replacement of some pressed board, slightly the wrong size, painted to match and not matching. In nineteen years nobody has fixed it. In nineteen years nobody but me has ever seen it.

• • •

FIVE

AE Day 14

I should deal with the counting, because you have noticed it, and because if I leave it alone you will make it into more than it is.

I count things. Ceiling panels. Diamonds in wire glass. Stairs. The people who walk past a man with his palm out. It is a habit of long standing and it is entirely automatic and it does not distress me. I understand that in certain quarters it would be called a symptom, and I understand what would be said about it, and I have read enough to construct that conversation myself and skip it.

It began in a room when I was a child. I am not going to describe the room. It has nothing to do with what follows and it is the kind of detail that people seize on because it is easier to hold than an argument. Every man alive has a room. If having a room were sufficient the streets would be full of us.

What I will say about the counting is the practical part, which is that it fills a channel. There is a channel in a person that must have something moving through it or the person will start to think, and thinking, in certain situations, is unsurvivable. You cannot think your way through the fourth hour of something. You can count your way through it. The numbers go in and they occupy the space where the screaming would otherwise be, and they are infinite, which is their great advantage, because whatever is happening to you is not.

So: a coping mechanism, correctly identified, of no further interest. Move on.

What I want to talk about instead is Ruth Mackey, because she comes into this later and it would be unfair to introduce her at the

moment she becomes useful to me.

Ruth had Window 7. She was fifty-nine and had been in that hall since she was twenty-eight, which is thirty-one years, which is longer than anyone. She wore cardigans in five colors on a rotation I never cracked. She kept a tin of butterscotch in her drawer and gave them to children in the line and to adults who were crying, which is a distinction she made without appearing to make it.

Ruth was good at the job in a way I was not. I was fast and I was accurate. Ruth was neither, particularly. What Ruth had was a way of leaning into the grille that made the glass seem thinner, and she remembered names, and if you had told her about your mother in February she would ask about your mother in June, and people came back to that hall and stood in Ruth's line specifically, letting the shorter lines go, waiting an extra hour for Window 7.

Her numbers were the worst in the district. Every quarter the district manager sent a sheet with the eleven of us ranked by matters closed, and every quarter Ruth was eleventh, and every quarter she pinned the sheet to the corkboard behind her chair like a school report.

I ate lunch with her most days on the fire stairs between the second and third floors, because the break room had a television in it that could not be turned off.

That week she asked me if I was all right. She asked twice. The first time I said I was fine and she accepted it, and the second time — this was the Thursday — she waited about ten seconds after I said it and then she said, "Marty," and nothing else, just my name with a small hook on the end of it, and left the space open.

And I felt the pull of it. I want that on the record. There was a moment on a concrete stair with a sandwich in my hand where I

came very close to telling Ruth Mackey about a corridor thirty-one feet long and a clock above a door, and about a folder with twelve initialed sheets in it, and about the fact that a six-year-old had been told her father was coming.

What stopped me was not pride. It was arithmetic, and it was correct.

Ruth had forty minutes for lunch. She had a mother in a facility out past the airport, and a sister who did not help, and a back that had been going for two years and would not be attended to because attending to it meant days off. She was eleventh on the sheet, which meant she was already spending more of herself than she had, every day, on the people in her line. If I put my thing on the stairs between us it would not be free. It would be paid for. It would come out of the tin of butterscotch, out of somebody's name remembered in June, out of the four minutes of some woman in the queue on Monday who would get three and a half because Ruth Mackey was tired.

There is a finite quantity of attention in a city and it is not distributed by merit. It is distributed by proximity and by luck and by who spoke first. If I took Ruth's, someone I would never meet would go without, and they would experience that as the world being cold, and they would be wrong, because the truth is that the warmth had simply already been spent, on me, on the stairs, on a Thursday.

So I said: "Long month. It's the quarter."

And she said, "It's always the quarter," and unwrapped a butterscotch and put it on the step between us and did not look at me while she did it, which is how you offer a thing to someone who cannot accept it directly.

I took it. I did not eat it. It stayed in my coat pocket for eleven weeks and I found it later, at a moment I will come to, and by then it had gone soft and misshapen inside the wrapper, the way sugar does when it has been carried too long against a body.

I have thought a great deal about that Thursday since. It is the last exit. If you are reading this and looking for the place where it could have gone another way, that is it, that is the stair, that is the ten seconds Ruth Mackey held open and I did not walk through.

But I want to be precise about what was on offer, because this is where people get sentimental and sentimentality is how the whole thing keeps running. What was on offer was not rescue. Ruth could not have refiled my petition or moved my hearing or restored four months of certificates. What was on offer was that one other person in Bellhaven would have known.

That is all. That is the entire product. Somebody knows.

And I had already worked out, by then, in the corridor, standing at the wire glass counting ninety-six diamonds, that knowing does nothing. That there is no mechanism by which another person's knowledge of your situation applies any force to your situation. That the warmth of being known is real and is worth something and is, in the end, a consolation prize that we have all agreed to call the main event because the main event is not available.

I was wrong about that. I want to say so plainly here, at the top, while it can still be said cleanly.

I was wrong about that, and I did not find out I was wrong until AE Day 63, in a room with no clock in it, and by then the finding out was worth nothing at all.

PART TWO — COMPOUNDING

AE Day 23

The thing I had not understood, and which I discovered on a Wednesday in the third week, is that a delay is not an event. A delay is a solvent.

She came in on the twenty-third day with three problems instead of one, and she did not know they were the same problem, and I did, and that is the whole of what happened that day.

The first was the lease. Her building had changed hands in the autumn, as buildings do in the blocks north of the Draw, and the new holder had begun the process by which such holders begin, which is to require that everything be documented afresh. Her share of the rent was set against her benefit category. The category was the one that had issued in error. Until the corrected determination arrived, the paper in her hand said she was in a bracket she was not in, and the management office had no discretion, and the man in the management office was correct.

The second was her hours. The laundry service on the Draw had put her on a schedule that required a certificate of continued eligibility, because the laundry service held a municipal contract and the municipal contract carried a clause, and the clause was there for good reasons that had been argued over by people who wanted to protect workers, and it had been drafted by people who assumed the certificate would arrive. Her certificate was generated automatically from the same field. Wrong field, no certificate. Reduced from thirty-one hours to nineteen.

The third was a medication authorization for her brother, and I will come to her brother, but not yet.

She laid them out on the shelf under the grille in the order they had happened, three papers, and she had drawn arrows on a fourth sheet, connecting them, because she was trying to show me the shape.

She said: "They're all the same thing. It's the code. It's all the code."

She was right. She was completely right, and she had worked it out alone, in a laundry, in three weeks, with no training and no access, and I have watched attorneys take longer.

I said: "I know."

And this is where I have to describe what I felt, and it is not what you are expecting, and it is worse.

I felt the way a man feels when a machine he has operated for nineteen years, in the dark, by touch, without ever once seeing the whole of it — turns and shows him its side. I had spent my working life at a single window in a single hall, seeing exactly one facet of exactly one problem per person per four minutes. And here, spread on a steel shelf in a woman's careful handwriting, with arrows, was the machine. Not a metaphor. The actual apparatus, drawn to scale, by someone standing inside it.

One error, unresolved, had become her housing, her income, and her brother's medicine.

I had done nothing since the morning she first came to my window. Nothing. I had typed one code, once, in nine seconds, and then I had gone home eighteen times, and slept, and come back, and in the intervening three weeks the city had done all of this by itself, on its own power, without instruction, the way water finds the lowest room in a house.

I want to be honest about the feeling because the feeling is the crime, if there is one. It was not pleasure. I have gone over it many times looking for pleasure and it is not there. It was *relief*. It was the specific relief of a man who has been carrying a private and shameful theory about the world and is handed the proof.

Because if a code can do this — if four characters, entered correctly, by a man committing no error, can dismantle a competent woman's life in twenty-three days — then a traffic light can do it. Then a closed street can do it. Then eleven minutes can do it, and the eleven minutes are not a judgment on the man who lost them. They are weather. And a man ruined by weather is not a failure. He is a casualty, which is a different word, and it has dignity in it.

I called this feeling clarity. I called it that at the time and I wrote it down that evening on the back of a transit receipt, the only note I have ever made about any of it: *clarity, day 23*. I have the receipt. It is soft now.

It was not clarity. Clarity is when you see the thing. What I had was the opposite: I had finally found a way to not see one particular thing, and the relief of no longer seeing it was so enormous that I mistook it for vision.

She was still talking. She had come to the practical part, which is always last, because people who are drowning are polite enough to give you the background first.

She said: "So what I need is — is there any way to make it faster."

There was. There were two ways, actually. I could have written a memorandum requesting expedition on hardship grounds, which succeeds perhaps one time in five and takes ten minutes to draft. Or I could have telephoned the unit and asked the clerk to walk it, which is not procedure, and which works, and which every one of us

did four or five times a year for the cases that got under our skin.

I said: "I can't expedite from this window."

Which is true. Expedition is not a function of Window 9. It is a memorandum written by a person at Window 9 and sent upward, which is a different sentence, and I chose the first sentence, and every word in it was accurate.

She said thank you.

She said thank you, and she gathered her three papers and the fourth sheet with the arrows on it, and she squared them on the shelf, tap, tap, the way she did, and she said: "Sorry to take up your time."

Behind her the queue went back to the doors. Forty, maybe forty-five people. Some of them had been there since seven. Each of them was going to get four minutes of me, or a little less, because she had already had eleven, and the arithmetic does not forgive, and every second I had spent on Dalia Reyes had been taken out of the pockets of people standing in the rain on Kelder Street who had never heard her name.

That is the part nobody says out loud. Kindness is not free and it is not even paid for by the person being kind. It is paid for by the eleventh person in line.

I said: "Next, please."

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SEVEN

BE Day 2 — the drive

I left at eight-fifteen for a nine-thirty hearing four and a half miles away and I want you to sit with that number for a moment before you decide anything about me.

Seventy-five minutes. Four and a half miles. That is a walking pace with forty minutes of contingency stapled to it. I had driven the route on the Sunday to time it. Twenty-two minutes on a Sunday. I had allowed for triple.

The car was a 1994 sedan with a hundred and ninety thousand miles on it and a booster seat in the back. The booster seat had been in the back since October. It was not needed and it was not used and I had not taken it out, and I do not intend to explain that.

8:15. Rain, the usual, the kind that beads and doesn't run. Bellhaven in April is a city that has been left in the sink.

8:31. Stopped on Marrow at the ramp. Nothing unusual — Marrow backs up at that hour, everyone knows it, I had allowed for it. I had the folder on the passenger seat with a rubber band around it. Twelve initialed sheets. Four months.

8:52. Still on Marrow. Moved perhaps two hundred yards in twenty minutes. There was no accident. I want to be clear that there was never an accident, at any point that morning. Nothing happened. That is the thing about traffic that people who write about traffic never get right: there is no cause. Six thousand people made individually reasonable decisions about when to leave their houses and the sum of those decisions was a solid.

9:04. I got off Marrow at the Kelder exit and went east, which was a mistake, and I knew it was a mistake within ninety seconds, and by then there was no way to unmake it.

9:12. I called the courthouse from a phone on Vessel and Ninth, in the rain, with the receiver hot from the last person's ear. I have the number by heart still. It rang eleven times. Then it stopped ringing and there was a click and then it started ringing again, which is what that switchboard did, and I understand now that it was rolling to the clerk's desk, and I understand now that the clerk was in session, standing beside a judge, reading numbers.

There is no answering machine at a courthouse. Think about that for a second. There is no answering machine at the place where they decide about your child.

9:26. Vessel Street was closed at Ninth. A barricade, two sawhorses, orange tape, a city truck with its lights going and no one visible inside it, and a length of sidewalk cordoned around an open plate in the roadway. There was no work being done. I sat there for four minutes and no one came out of the truck and nothing came out of the hole. I have since made an inquiry and established that the closure was scheduled, was properly noticed in the municipal bulletin fourteen days in advance, and was lifted at 11:00 that morning.

It was lawful. Everything that morning was lawful.

9:31. Parked eleven blocks out, on a slope, badly, with the folder under my coat.

9:38. Ran the last two blocks. Bellhaven in the rain, a Tuesday morning, the sidewalks full — the Ossuary district at half nine is the densest street in the city, lawyers and clerks and families and the men who sell umbrellas out of holdalls, all of it moving, all of it in

the wet, and I went through the middle of it at a dead run with a folder inside my coat and my mouth open.

Nobody stopped me. Nobody asked. Why would they. I counted, afterward, in the way that I do: I passed something on the order of four hundred people in those two blocks, and not one of them turned their head, and every single one of them was correct not to. A running man in a city is nothing. He is late for something. Everyone is late for something. If you turned your head for every man running in the rain in Bellhaven you would never get anywhere yourself, and the people who depend on you would suffer for it, and that would be your fault.

That is the horror I have been trying to explain to you and I am not sure I can, so let me put it as plainly as I know how:

Nobody looked up, and nobody should have.

There was no villain on Vessel Street that morning. There was a properly noticed roadwork, a switchboard functioning as designed, a volume of traffic within normal range, four hundred pedestrians minding their own business as any decent person does, and one man running through the middle of it with everything he had in a folder under his coat.

The elevator in the Vessel Street courthouse was out of service, which had been reported, and which was scheduled for repair, and which had a sign on it.

Four flights. Fifty-two stairs. I counted them going up, one, two, three, four, all fifty-two, because the channel has to have something moving through it.

9:41.

EIGHT

AE Day 31

I would like to describe a man at a desk doing nothing, because it is the center of this account and because it will not look like anything.

By the fourth week I had stopped working her file and started watching it.

The distinction is not visible from outside. A file in our system is a screen with eleven fields and a scrolling history, and whether a man is reading it in order to act or reading it in order to observe, he is doing the same thing with his face and his hands. If you had been standing behind me you would have seen a fifty-one-year-old civil servant in a grey cardigan looking at a monitor, and you would have looked away, because there is nothing on earth less interesting.

I opened it every morning before the doors. That was the shape of it. I came in at ten past eight, and the hall was still dark at the far end where the north windows don't reach, and I would sit down at Window 9 with the coat still on and put in the matter number, and read what had happened overnight.

Usually nothing had. That is the first thing to understand about watching a file: the overwhelming majority of what you see is the absence of anything, and that absence is not empty, it is *cumulative*, the way a debt is cumulative. Every morning of nothing is a morning that has been spent.

But some mornings there was a line, and the lines were the most interesting text I have ever read.

04/11 — ELIG UNIT 3 — REC'D, LOGGED, QUEUE POS 214.

Two hundred and fourteen. That was the position her correction occupied in the queue of a unit that would eventually determine it did not belong to them. I sat and looked at that number for a long time. It clears at eleven to fourteen a day. I did the arithmetic on the back of a routing slip, and then I did it again because the first answer seemed unreasonable, and it wasn't.

04/19 — HOUS AUTH BLHVN — INQUIRY, NO REC.

That is the management office on her building, asking the housing authority whether a corrected determination exists. It does not exist. So: no record. Two words. Somewhere on the north side of the Draw a man in a leasing office read *no record* and put a form in a drawer, and he was not cruel, he had simply asked a question and received an accurate answer.

04/26 — CONTRACT COMPL — CERT NOT GENERATED — AUTO.

That one is my favorite, if that is the word, and I do not think it is. *Auto*. No person is named because no person was involved. A routine ran at some hour of the night in a room in this city that I have never seen, and it examined a field, and the field was wrong, and it declined to generate a certificate, and it wrote one line, and it moved on to the next of forty thousand. That routine has no author still living in the department. It was written in 1998.

I want to say what it was actually like, sitting there.

It was like standing at the rail of a bridge over a river you have crossed every day for nineteen years, and looking down for the first time, and seeing that it is not water. That it is a machine. That it has always been a machine, running under everything, enormous and patient and entirely indifferent, and that the only reason you never heard it is that you were on the bridge.

And nobody built it. That is the part that gets into your chest and stays there. There is no room where a man sits deciding these things. There are eleven units and a form with one routing field and a queue that clears at eleven to fourteen a day and a routine from 1998, and the sum of all that, the *sum*, is a woman losing her hours at a laundry on the Draw.

I did nothing. I want to be very precise about the nothing, because the nothing is the method and the method is the whole confession.

There is a key on that terminal, F6, which opens a routing correction. It takes about forty seconds to complete. It requires no authorization, no supervisor, no memorandum. It is not a favor. It is not discretion. It is the ordinary correction of an ordinary field, and I have pressed it perhaps six hundred times in nineteen years, for people whose faces I never retained.

Every morning I looked at the file and did not press F6, and at eight-thirty the doors opened and the line came in out of the weather, and I said good morning to the first of sixty-two.

That is it. That is the entire crime, if it is one. A man declining to press a key.

You cannot photograph it. You cannot testify to it. There is no record anywhere in the Bellhaven municipal system of a key not pressed, and there never will be, and if you went looking you would find only a man with the third-best closure numbers in the district doing his job at a rate slightly above the mean.

I have thought about whether there is a word for what I was. The closest I can get is not *saboteur* and not *bureaucrat*. It is *audience*.

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NINE

AE Day 40

On the fortieth day I did the only thing in this account that I would describe as a decision, and it took under a minute, and it consisted of eleven words spoken in a corridor.

The situation was this. She had begun coming in on Mondays, because Mondays are the worst day and she had worked out that the worst day was the only day she could take off. And on the second Monday she came in, she did not stand in my line.

She stood in Ruth's.

I understood immediately what would happen, and I want to be clear that what would happen was good, and correct, and the system functioning exactly as designed. Ruth would take twenty minutes instead of four. Ruth would ask what she actually needed rather than what she had come to ask about, which is a different question and the only one that matters. Ruth would find the routing error in perhaps ninety seconds because Ruth had been looking at that screen since 1995 and knew the shape of a misrouted correction the way a farmer knows weather.

And then Ruth would press F6.

I stood up from Window 9 and went out through the staff door into the corridor behind the hall, which is a passage of grey painted brick with a linoleum floor and a smell of toner and old paper and, faintly, always, the drains. There is a water cooler halfway along it. I filled a paper cone and did not drink it.

Marisol Vega came past with a stack. She was the floor supervisor, thirty-eight, competent, decent, overloaded — she covered eleven windows and a rotating staff and the district metrics, and she ate standing up.

I said: "Reyes, in Mackey's line. She's mine — I've been running her since March."

Eleven words. Count them.

Now: every one of those words is true. Continuity of handling is a real principle in that office and a good one. When two officers work the same matter you get contradictory advice and duplicated routing and a claimant who has been told two different things by the department and no longer trusts either. It wastes everyone's time. It is bad for the claimant. There is a line about it in the handbook.

Marisol said, "Okay," and kept walking, because she had a stack in her hands and forty other things and no reason on earth to interrogate a nineteen-year officer's claim to a file he had in fact been handling since March.

Two minutes later I watched through the staff door as Ruth said something to Dalia and pointed, kindly, apologetically, the way Ruth did everything, toward Window 9.

And Dalia crossed the marble. She crossed it with her folder held against her chest and she got into my line, at the back, position sixteen or seventeen, and she stood there for an hour and ten minutes.

That is the crossing. If there is a moment in this account where I stopped being a man observing a machine and became part of it, that is the moment, and it lasted less than sixty seconds, and it happened in a corridor by a water cooler, and it consisted of a true

statement made to a busy woman about departmental continuity.

I have tried since to find the language that would make it visible. *Isolation of the subject* is the phrase you would use in a laboratory. *Interference with the receipt of assistance* is the phrase you would use in a hearing, if you could prove it, which you could not.

At the time, standing there with a paper cone of water going warm in my hand, what I thought was: *I am protecting the integrity of the experiment.*

That is what a man says at the moment he ceases to be observing anything. The instant you have to protect the conditions, you are not watching the world. You are building a room and calling it the world.

When she got to my window at twenty past eleven she said she was sorry for the wait. She said the other lady had been really helpful, actually, and had almost worked it out, and had said something about a correction, but then had said it was better if she came to me because I knew the history.

I said: "That's right. I know the history."

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TEN

BE Day 16

The visits happened at a family contact centre on Kelder Street, eight blocks from the hall where I work, in a building that had previously been a dentist's and had not been thoroughly converted. There was still a frosted panel in one door with the outline of a name scraped off it.

There were twelve of these visits over four months and I attended every one and each of them was documented on a sheet initialed by the supervising officer, and those sheets were in a folder under a rubber band on a passenger seat on a Tuesday morning in April. I want to put this one down while I still can, because it is the only one I am going to write.

Room 2. Two o'clock to three o'clock. A low table, four chairs of the stacking kind, a rug with roads printed on it that was too small for the room, a box of toys that had been given by somebody's church and had the tired look that shared toys get, all the good pieces gone. One window with a blind in it, the blind half down, the slats bent in the middle where people had pushed them apart to look out.

The supervising officer was a woman named Petra who sat in the corner with a clipboard, and I want to say something about Petra because she becomes important later in a way she will never know.

Petra had eleven of these to observe a week. She was perhaps twenty-nine. She sat in the corner and made a note at the start and a note at the end and in between she was, in the main, on her phone, thumb moving, screen light on her face in a room with the blind half down.

I resented her enormously at the time. I want to record the resentment honestly and then take it back, because it is the same resentment I will spend the rest of this account dismantling.

Petra was correct. Petra's job was to certify that a visit occurred and that nothing improper happened in it. She was not there to witness anything. She was not there to be moved. If Petra had allowed herself to be moved by every hour she sat through in that room she would have lasted five months, and the eleven families the following week would have had no observer at all, and every one of their visits would have been cancelled, because the contact centre does not run without an observer in the corner.

Her indifference was load-bearing. Somebody had to not care, or the room did not open.

Mara was six. She came in ahead of the transport worker at a run, in a red coat with the hood up indoors, and she went straight past me to the toy box because that is what six is.

We built a thing. I do not know what it was. It had a wall and then it had a road going into the wall, and this was apparently correct and I was corrected when I suggested otherwise. She had a scab on her left knee that she was very proud of and showed me twice. She told me about a girl called Fen who was, on the evidence, either her closest friend or her mortal enemy, and about a song they had learned that she sang two lines of and then stopped, because she had forgotten the rest, and she was annoyed about it, and she said she would learn it and sing me all of it next time.

She asked me whether I still had the car. I said yes. She said, is the seat still in it. I said yes.

She said okay.

At ten to three Petra said, "Five minutes," without looking up, and made a note.

Mara drew me a picture in the last five minutes, which she did every time, and this one was of the wall and the road going into it, and there were two figures, one large and one small, and the small one was on the road side of the wall and the large one was not. I have not read anything into that and I am not going to. She was six. She drew a wall because we had built a wall.

I folded it in four and put it in my coat.

At three o'clock she went out with the transport worker and I heard her in the corridor telling the transport worker about the scab.

And here is the part I did not understand for four months, and did not understand in the corridor with the wire glass, and did not understand until much later, and which I would ask you to hold in your hand for a moment because it is small and heavy and it is the actual injury under all of this:

Somebody had to tell her.

Not on that day. On a Tuesday in April, at some point between half past nine and the end of the school day, a person in a house on the other side of Bellhaven had to find a form of words for a six-year-old in a red coat who had been told her father was coming, and who had learned the rest of a song.

I do not know who did it. I do not know what they said. I have never been told and I will never ask, because there is no version of the asking that is not for me.

Twelve visits. Twelve initialed sheets. Four months of classes with certificates. A letter from a supervisor, a letter from a landlord,

receipts.

Eleven minutes.

PART THREE — ACEDIA

AE Day 58

There is a word the monastics used for the thing that came for them in the middle of the day. Not despair — they had a separate word for despair, and they respected it, because despair is at least a form of caring. This other thing they called the noonday demon, and what it did was not make you sad. It made you unable to attend. It emptied the hours of their weight. A man in its grip could sit in his cell in perfect health, harming no one, performing every office correctly, and be entirely absent from his own life, and the reason they called it a sin rather than an illness is that they had noticed it spreads, and that it spreads by example, and that it looks from the outside exactly like calm.

I mention this because on the fifty-eighth day Dalia Reyes stopped asking me about the form.

It happened without announcement. She came to the window at nine-forty, and she had the folder, and I had already opened the file and prepared the sentence — the sentence was **IN REVIEW**, it had been **IN REVIEW** for fifty-eight days and it would have been **IN REVIEW** for another six hundred — and she put the folder down on the shelf, closed, and did not open it.

And she said: "How long have you worked here?"

I have been asked that question perhaps four times in nineteen years. Twice it was hostile — a preamble to *and you still don't know how to do it*. Once it was a man making conversation while I retrieved something. Once it was Ruth, on her second day, in 1995, before I was born into that hall.

This was none of those. She asked it the way you ask a question you have been carrying for a while and have decided to spend.

I said: "Nineteen years."

She said: "At this window?"

"At this window."

She nodded slowly and she did not say anything for about four seconds, and I registered, somewhere at the back, that four seconds of silence at a service window is an extraordinarily long time, and that the woman behind her in the line had shifted her weight.

Then she said: "Do you like it?"

I gave her an answer. I am not going to pretend it was profound. I said something about the work being necessary, which is true, and about the volume, which is also true, and she listened to all of it with her head very slightly tilted, and when I finished she said, "That's not what I asked," and she smiled when she said it, and there was nothing sharp in the smile at all.

I said: "No. It isn't."

And she waited.

That is what she did. She waited. She stood at a service window in a hall with forty people behind her and a folder she did not open, and she gave me the silence, and she did not fill it, and she did not look away.

I have gone back over the following weeks a great many times and this is where they start.

At the time I made an error of interpretation which I now understand to have been the most consequential misreading of my

life. I thought: *she likes me*. Not romantically — I want to head that off, there is none of that in this account and there never was. I thought she had decided I was on her side. I thought that after fifty-eight days of a man behind glass being unfailingly courteous to her, she had concluded that the courtesy was real and that I was the one decent thing in the machine, and had begun, in the way of lonely people, to treat me as a person rather than a function.

That was not what was happening.

What was happening was that Dalia Reyes had worked out, some time in the previous fortnight, that the delay was not weather.

I do not know exactly when. She never told me and I never asked, because asking would have been an admission. But I have reconstructed it, and I believe it was around the fiftieth day, and I believe the thing that gave me away was not any single act but the pattern — that I was warm, and competent, and never wrong, and never quick. She had spent three months learning the system's grammar. She had learned that incompetence has a texture and that this did not have it.

And having worked it out, she found herself in a position with no moves in it.

Consider what she actually had. No evidence. Two lawful routing codes. A queue position. A functioning switchboard. Not one thing she could put in a complaint that would not read, in the hand of any reviewing officer in the district, as a woman who had waited a long time and become upset about it, which is the most common document in that building and the least regarded.

She could not fight me. She could not escape me — Marisol had seen to that, at my request, in a corridor, in eleven words.

So she did the only thing left, and it was not the thing anyone would predict, and I have never fully recovered from it.

She started paying attention to me.

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TWELVE

AE Day 63

She asked for a room.

You can do that. It is in the notices on the wall, in three languages, and almost nobody reads them: a claimant may request that a matter be discussed in a private interview room where the matter involves sensitive circumstances. It exists mostly for domestic cases. It is used perhaps twice a month.

The rooms are off the corridor behind the hall, past the water cooler. Room 4 is eight feet by ten, grey painted brick, a table bolted to the floor, four chairs not bolted to anything, a strip light in a cage, and nothing else. No window. No clock. That last detail is deliberate and it is in the handbook: no clock, because a clock in an interview room communicates that the interview has a length, and the department's position is that a claimant should not feel timed.

I have been in that room perhaps two hundred times. I had never once been in it without a clock inside my own head.

She sat down across the table with the folder in front of her and did not open it, and she said: "I want to ask you about something, and it isn't the form."

I said that I had, realistically, about ten minutes.

She said: "Okay."

We were in there for two hours and forty minutes. I know the number because I checked the terminal when I came out, and then I looked at it a second time.

I am not going to give you all of it. Most of it was not important, and the parts that were important were not the parts where anything was said. But I will give you the shape, because the shape is the thing.

She began by asking me what happens to a file. Not hers — a file, any file, in general. What actually physically happens. Where does it go, who touches it, is it paper, is it a screen, is there a room.

I answered. It is a technical question and I am good at technical questions and it was, at that point, still a conversation I was in control of. I told her about the eleven units. I told her about the routing field. I explained queue positions and the eleven-to-fourteen clearance and why a unit returns a matter rather than forwarding it, which has to do with an audit rule written after a scandal in the seventies and which is, on balance, a good rule.

She listened to all of it. That is not a figure of speech. She listened the way almost nobody listens — without preparing a response, without waiting for the gap, and when she did not understand a term she stopped me and made me say it again, and when I said it again she repeated it back with the stress in the right place.

Nobody had done that to me since I was a young man.

I want to try to describe what that is like when it has not happened to you for a very long time, and I am aware that I am going to fail.

It is not pleasant. That is the first thing. People imagine that being attended to is a warm sensation, and it is not, or not initially — initially it is closer to being cold. There is a physical component. There is a sensation in the chest and the throat like the one you get in a lift that starts down. Because a man who has been unattended for nineteen years has built an entire architecture on the assumption that the space around him is empty, and he has been

putting things in that space — small unfinished things, unedited things, the true version of sentences — and now someone is standing in it, and everything he has left lying there is visible.

I found myself talking about the tin ceiling. About the panel over the third window that is not tin. I have never told anyone that. There is no reason to tell anyone that. It is the most private thing about me, and it came out at something like the fortieth minute, in a room with no clock, and she said: "Which window?" and I said "The third," and she said, "I'll look on the way out."

I'll look on the way out.

Somewhere past ninety minutes she moved without appearing to move. I have tried to identify the sentence and I cannot. But at some point we were no longer discussing the department.

She asked what I did before. I said the same thing, elsewhere. She asked whether I had ever wanted something else, and I said I had wanted to teach, briefly, at twenty-three, and that this was so long ago it was effectively a thing I had read about someone.

She asked if there was anybody at home.

I said no.

She said: "Was there?"

The strip light in Room 4 has a fault in it. It is not a flicker — a flicker you would notice and report. It is a cycle, perhaps eleven seconds long, where the light gets very slightly thinner and then comes back, and in nineteen years I do not believe another officer in that building has ever detected it. I counted eleven of those cycles before I answered, which is a hundred and twenty-one seconds, and she let me have every one of them.

And then I told her.

Not all of it. I did not give her the corridor. I gave her the outline: that there had been a hearing in April, that I had been eleven minutes late, that a continuance had been entered, that the continuance was fourteen weeks, and that a six-year-old had been told her father was coming.

I said it flatly. I said it in the voice I use for queue positions. I have discovered since that this is what it sounds like when you have not said a thing out loud and the first saying comes out in the only register you have left.

She did not say she was sorry. I want that noted. In three months the phrase *I'm sorry* passed between us perhaps thirty times and every one of them was hers, apologizing for taking up my time, and at the one moment where the whole civilized machinery of sympathy would have fired in any normal person, she did not use it.

What she said was: "Eleven minutes."

I said yes.

She said: "And they'd already gone."

I said yes.

And she put her hands flat on the table and looked at them for a while, and then she said the thing that ended it.

She said: "Who did that to you before?"

I asked her what she meant.

She said: "Because you weren't surprised. When you tell it, you're not surprised. You're — you're explaining a rule. Like you already knew the rule and you were just checking."

Eleven seconds of thin light and back.

I said: "Everyone had a childhood."

She started to say something and I went over the top of her, which I had not done once in three months, and I heard my own voice go up in a room with a bolted table in it, and what I said was this. I remember it because it is the only thing I have ever said in that building that I would take back.

I said: "That's the cheap version. That's the version they sell. A man's life goes wrong and you go rooting in the childhood for the thing that explains it, because if there's a thing then the world is still in order, isn't it. Then it isn't the world. Then it's just him, he was damaged, he came pre-broken, and everybody else can go home. Everybody had a childhood. Everybody had a room. It doesn't take a room. That's my whole point — that's the entire *point* — it doesn't take anything at all, it takes eleven minutes on a Tuesday, and if you understood that you would be as frightened as I am."

She did not answer.

She sat in the chair with her hands flat on the table in a room with no clock and she looked at me, and she went on looking at me, and I could not hold it, and I looked at the wall, and then I looked at the table, and then — and I am going to write this down because I have decided to write all of it — I put my hand over my eyes.

There was a very long silence.

Then she said, quietly: "It's the code, isn't it. It's the routing code."

And I said: "It's in review."

THIRTEEN

BE Day 2 — 9:41 to the end of it

He said: *That matter was called at nine-thirty.*

The red sweep hand went around once.

I said: "I'm here. I'm here now, it's — look, it's quarter to. I'm eleven minutes."

He said, and I want to reproduce this accurately because he was kind and because his kindness is the point: "I know. I'm sorry. It's already been taken up."

I said: "Then take it up again."

And he explained, and the explanation was correct in every particular. The matter had been called. The matter had been heard in my absence. A hearing does not pause; it is a slot on a docket, forty-one matters that morning, and the room does not hold a place for a man who is not in it, because if it held a place for one it would hold a place for all of them, and then nothing would ever be heard by anybody. He told me a determination had issued. He told me what the determination was, which was that in the absence of the moving party the existing arrangement stood, and the matter was continued to a date to be assigned.

He was maybe twenty-six years old and he had told this to a great many people and he did not enjoy it.

I said: "For how long."

He looked at the screen. He did the thing where you tilt your head slightly because you hope the number will be different.

He said: "It's showing fourteen weeks."

Fourteen weeks.

There is a thing that happens in the body at that moment and I do not have the equipment to describe it, so I will describe the room instead. There is a bench along the left wall, oak, worn pale in two places. There is a window at the far end with wire mesh in the glass. There is a door on the right marked 410. Above the door there is a clock with a red sweep hand, and behind the door a woman's voice was reading numbers, and each number was four seconds long, and each one was somebody's.

I said: "She's six."

He said — and this is where it becomes unbearable, and I want you to understand that nothing improper occurred, that this young man did his job impeccably and could not have done otherwise — he said:

"I understand."

• • •

My attorney came out at ten past ten with her phone against her chest.

Her name was Ellen Cray and she was good. I want that recorded, because in the story people tell about a man like me there is always a bad lawyer, and there wasn't one. She had done everything correctly for four months. She had been unglamorous and thorough and she had cost me money I did not have, and she had earned it.

She said: "Oh, Martin."

She had another matter at eleven in a different room in the same building. She gave me eighteen minutes. I have never held it against her and I do not now: she had eighteen and she gave me all

eighteen, which is more than four, which is more than most people get from anybody in this city on any day of their lives.

She said: "This happens. I know how that sounds. It happens and it is survivable and we refile."

She said: "Nothing has been decided against you. Nobody has found anything about you. This is a scheduling event."

She said: "Fourteen weeks is not the end. You keep the visits, you keep the classes, you turn up to every single one, and you walk into the next one with sixteen sheets instead of twelve and it looks better, actually — it looks like consistency."

And every one of those sentences was true and professional and kindly meant, and I sat on a bench worn pale in two places and could not make her hear the only thing I had.

Because here is what I could not say, and I have had a long time now to find the words and I still do not have them.

The delay was the ruling.

Not a step toward the ruling. The ruling. The court did not have to decide against me. It did not have to find me unfit or unsafe or wanting. It only had to be slow, and slowness is a verdict that nobody has to sign, and that no one can appeal, because there is no defendant. You cannot cross-examine fourteen weeks.

Fourteen weeks is a season. In fourteen weeks a six-year-old learns the rest of a song, and loses a tooth, and develops a fear of something and gets over it, and the man who was not there for any of that does not become a man who missed fourteen weeks. He becomes a man who is *not usually there*, which is a different kind of man, and the next hearing will look at that man and it will be

correct about him.

The machine does not have to want anything. That is what I could not transmit. It does not have to be cruel or corrupt or even inattentive. It only has to have a cycle time, and my daughter is six, and those two facts are in different units and cannot be converted, and everyone I spoke to that day was standing on the correct side of a conversion that does not exist.

Ellen said: "I understand."

She meant it. She meant it more than the young man at the window had meant it, and she was a better person than he was, and she had eighteen minutes and gave me all of them.

And I understood, sitting there, with total clarity, and with no anger at her at all, that there was no sentence I could construct out of the English language which would transfer this from the inside of my head into hers. That the thing itself was untransmissible. That I could talk for a week and she would understand *that I was in pain*, which is not the same, which is in fact the opposite, because a person who understands that you are in pain has finished the transaction, and a person who understands the thing does not exist.

• • •

I did not go home.

I walked. I walked from Vessel Street north as far as the Draw and then west along the water with the rain doing its thin Bellhaven work, and the city did what the city does at that hour, which is nothing whatsoever. Men unloading a truck. A woman arguing into a phone in front of a shuttered pawnbroker's with the grille still down at eleven in the morning. Three schoolchildren under one coat. A bus going past with its windows fogged and every face inside

it turned toward nothing.

I tried four times.

I want to put them down because I have never told anyone and because it is the part that decided everything.

The first was Ellen, in the corridor, and I have described it.

The second was a man on the ferry stand at the Draw, a stranger, sixty-odd, who asked me if I was all right, because I must have looked like something. And I said yes. That was my failure, not his. He asked. He was the one person in Bellhaven who asked me anything that morning and I said yes, because you do, because the truthful answer requires forty minutes and he had offered four seconds, and because I could see over his shoulder that the ferry was coming.

The third was my sister, from a phone on Ansel Row at two in the afternoon. She lives nine hundred miles away. She was at work. I got most of it out, in the wrong order, and she said all the right things and she said them fast because she was at work, and at the end she said, "I'll call you tonight," and she did call me that night, and I did not pick up, and that is on me as well.

The fourth was Ruth Mackey on the fire stairs eleven days later, and I have already told you about that, and about the butterscotch, and about the arithmetic that stopped me, and the arithmetic was correct.

So: four attempts, and in every case the failure was structural, and in two of them the failure was mine, and in none of them was there a villain.

It was somewhere between the second and the third that I stopped.

I want to be careful here, because this is the only moment in this account that could be called a conversion, and it did not feel like one. There was no decision. There was no vow. I was standing at the rail on the west side of the Draw in the rain looking at the water, which is brown, and which moves in a way that does not suggest anywhere to go, and I noticed that I had begun composing the sentence again — the sentence you compose for the next person, the one that will finally contain it — and I noticed that I had been composing versions of that sentence continuously for five hours.

And I stopped composing it.

That is all. That is the whole event. A man at a rail stopped preparing an explanation.

It felt, at the time, like relief. It felt like putting down a suitcase. I remember thinking, with something close to gratitude, *oh — I don't have to do this.*

I went home. I made food and ate some of it. I did not sleep and this did not distress me. In the morning I put on a clean shirt and went to Kelder Street and sat down at Window 9 at ten past eight and said good morning to the first of sixty-two people, and I was courteous to every one of them, and my closure numbers that day were the second-best in the district.

Two days later a woman came to my window with her folder already open to the correct page, and said good morning, and waited for me to say it back.

AE Day 70

Her brother's name was Tomás and he was thirty-nine and he had a condition that required a maintained authorization, and the authorization was generated from the same field.

I had known this since the twenty-third day. She had told me, at the window, in the forty seconds that come after relief, and I had written nothing down because I did not need to.

I want to set out the mechanism plainly, because if I make it vague you will supply something worse or something more dramatic and either way you will get it wrong.

The authorization was not cancelled. Nobody cancelled anything. The authorization ran to a date, and on that date it required renewal, and the renewal drew on the eligibility category, and the eligibility category was the one that had issued in error on the ninth of April. The renewal did not fail. It did not issue. There is a difference, and the difference is a hundred percent of the reason no one is at fault: a failure produces a notice and a notice produces an appeal. A non-issuance produces nothing. It is not an event. It is the absence of one, and the system has no vocabulary for it, and neither does the law.

She came to my window on the sixty-eighth day about something else and mentioned it in passing, in the practical way she had, the way she mentioned everything — the pharmacy had said there was no current authorization, and she had rung a number, and the number had rung, and she was going to go in person on Thursday because Thursday was her short day.

I said: "That's a different office."

Which is true. It is a different office. It is on the fourth floor of a building on Marrow Street.

On the seventieth day I opened the file at ten past eight, in the dark end of the hall, with my coat still on, and there was a line in the history that had not been there on Friday, and it was not from us.

06/14 — HOSP BLLHVN GEN — SVC NOTIFICATION — ADMIT.

That is all it says. That is the entire text. A hospital had touched a benefits file, which is a thing that happens automatically, and the touch had left one line, and the line has four words in it.

I sat at Window 9 in a grey hall at twelve minutes past eight and read it about a dozen times.

I did not know what had happened. I want to be exact: I did not know then and I do not know now in any detail, because I never asked her and she never told me and there is no field in that system that says what a thing was like. I knew the class of event that follows an interrupted authorization of that type. I knew it was survivable. I knew that a man of thirty-nine goes into Bellhaven General and comes out, in the great majority of cases, and that what he comes out with is not the thing he went in with — that there is a category of harm which does not kill anybody and does not appear in any record as harm, and which simply subtracts something and does not give it back.

I knew also that a hospital admission generates its own paper. That it is a service notification. That a service notification against a household under active determination is the sort of thing that, in another building, on another floor, could be read by another officer

with four minutes to give it, and that the reading would be perfectly correct, and that what it would look like to that officer is a household in difficulty.

Here is what I need to tell you, and it is the worst sentence in this account.

I thought all of that through, in order, sitting at Window 9 with my coat on, in perhaps ninety seconds. And at the end of the ninety seconds I put my hand on the terminal, and I did not press F6, and at half past eight the doors opened and I said good morning to a man with a wet umbrella and I gave him his four minutes.

That is the decision. There is no other decision in this book. Everything before it was drift, and drift is a defence, and I am not going to be able to use it after this page.

I have tried since to reconstruct what I told myself and the honest answer is: very little. There was no argument. There was no moment where I weighed a man's health against a thesis, because to weigh them I would have had to hold them both at once, and I have never in my life been able to hold two things at once — that is the counting, that is what the counting is *for*, it is a channel with one thing moving through it and no room for the second.

What I had instead was a sentence, and the sentence was: *I didn't do it.*

And it is true. That is the thing about it. It remains true. I did not misroute her file; I selected one of two lawful codes. I did not interrupt an authorization; a renewal did not issue. I did not put a man in Bellhaven General; a condition did. Every link in that chain is a link that was already in the world before I got there, and all I did was decline, on nineteen consecutive mornings, to press a key that no rule required me to press.

It is a perfect defence. I have examined it from every side and I cannot find the flaw in it. It would survive any hearing in this city.

And I want to say — because this is the only place in this account where I can still say it and be believed — that on the seventieth day of my experiment I understood for the first time what I had actually discovered, and it was not what I set out to find.

I had set out to prove that a man can be destroyed by weather.

What I had proved is that the weather is made of men who each did nothing.

I did not accept that at the time. I put it down. I had a thesis to protect and a room to keep the conditions in, and I did what I had done in the corridor with the paper cone: I gave the thing a name that let me carry on. I called it *the cost of the study*.

That is the phrase. I wrote nothing down, but that is the phrase I used in my head, and I used it for the next twenty-one days, and I would like it on the record alongside the other one, alongside *clarity, day 23*, so that you can see the two of them together and watch what a man builds when he needs a roof.

• • •

AE Day 77

On the seventy-seventh day I telephoned Eligibility Unit 3.

I had a reason. I am always going to have a reason; you will have noticed that by now, and so had I. The reason was that the file had been sitting at queue position 214 for eleven weeks and by any ordinary reckoning it should have cleared and been returned, and a return would put it back on my desk, and back on my desk it becomes visible to Marisol in the monthly aging report, and an aging report is the one document in that building that makes a slow file into an event.

So I was going to call and check the position, and if it was close to clearing I was going to find a reason to have it re-queued, and I had already assembled the reason, and the reason was good, and I am not going to insult you by explaining it.

The woman who answered was called Denise. I want to describe her voice: cheerful, hoarse, the voice of somebody who has been on a telephone for thirty years in a room with no windows and has made her peace with it. I gave her the matter number. I heard the keys.

She said: "Oh — no, that one's flagged."

I said: "Flagged how?"

She said: "Frequent contact."

And she said it the way you say a thing that everybody knows. She said it the way you would say *that one's a duplicate* or *that one's out for signature*. There was nothing in her voice at all. There was no confession in it and no cruelty and no interest.

I asked her what that meant, and she told me, plainly, patiently, in about forty seconds, and I am going to give it to you as she gave it to me.

There is no such flag. Not officially. There is no field, there is no code, there is nothing in the handbook. What there is, is a practice. When a claimant contacts a unit repeatedly about the same matter — telephones, writes, attends in person, follows up — the contacts themselves generate work. Each one has to be logged. Each one has to be responded to. And a matter that generates six contacts a month is consuming more of that unit's capacity than a matter that generates none, and the unit has eleven to fourteen a day, and so somewhere, at some point, in some room, in some year before either Denise or I was hired, it became ordinary practice to move such matters down.

Not to refuse them. Never to refuse them. To move them down, because moving them down reduces the contacts, because a claimant who is told a new number stops calling for a while, and the calls are the cost.

The flag is a note in a shared spreadsheet on a departmental drive. Denise did not know who maintained it. She thought it might be Unit 3's own, or it might be district-wide; she had used it since she started, which was in 2004, and she had never once asked where it came from, in the way that you have never asked where the tradition of apologizing to a clerk came from.

I asked her when the matter had been flagged.

She said: "The eighth."

The eighth. That is AE Day 38.

Thirty-nine days ago. Two days before a corridor and a water cooler and a paper cone and eleven true words spoken to a busy woman about departmental continuity.

I asked her who had flagged it.

And she said, and I want this sentence set out on its own because I have carried it every day since:

"It doesn't say. It just says she calls a lot."

• • •

I sat with the receiver in my hand after she rang off, in the corridor behind the hall, under a strip light with a cycle in it, and I want to tell you what went through me and it was not guilt. I want to be honest to the end and it was not guilt.

It was humiliation.

Because I had thought I was doing something. I had a thesis. I had a method and a subject and a defensible record and a phrase for the cost. I had believed — and I understood in that corridor exactly how much I had believed it, by the size of the thing that went out of me — that I had discovered a mechanism in the world and had been brave enough to operate it, and that this made me, whatever else it made me, *awake*, in a hall full of people who were asleep at eleven windows.

And it was already in the spreadsheet.

It had been in the spreadsheet since before I typed the second code. Some woman in a room with no windows, in 2004 or 1996 or 1981, had arrived at the identical procedure with no philosophy at all — no bad day, no corridor, no wire glass divided into ninety-six diamonds, no dead child's song. She had arrived at it because the

phone kept ringing and the phone ringing was the cost, and she had moved the matter down, and it had worked, and she had done it again, and eventually somebody made a column for it.

I had not discovered anything. I had reinvented, at enormous personal expense, with a great deal of suffering and a small library of self-justification, a labour-saving practice.

That is the finding. That is the actual finding of the experiment, delivered on the seventy-seventh day by a hoarse cheerful woman on a telephone who had no idea she was delivering anything.

Cruelty does not require a bad day. Cruelty is the default. It is what a system does when nobody is spending attention, and nobody is spending attention because attention is expensive and there is not enough of it and there never was.

My bad day did not make me a monster.

It made me *notice*. That is all it did. It stripped out the thing that had been keeping my eyes off the machine, and I looked, and I saw what everyone in that building has been standing inside their whole lives, and I mistook the seeing for a summoning, and I thought the machine was mine.

I hung up the phone. I filled a paper cone from the cooler and did not drink it. Then I went back through the staff door into the hall, and the line was down the marble stairs and out the doors and along Kelder in the weather, and I sat down at Window 9 and said: "Next, please."

PART FOUR — WATER

AE Day 91

She solved it.

I have had a long time to arrange the sentences that follow and I have never found a better one to start with. She solved it. She sat down in front of the machine that had spent ninety-one days taking her life apart, and she read it correctly, and she found the one door in it that was open, and she went through.

She came to the window on the ninety-first day and she did not have the folder.

That is what I noticed first. Ninety-one days and I had never once seen her without it. She had her hands free and a paper cup of something from the place on the corner and she stood at the grille with her weight even on both feet, and something in her shoulders had changed, and for about two seconds I permitted myself to think that the correction had come through from another direction and that it was over.

She said: "I wanted to tell you in person."

Then she told me.

There is a provision — it is not obscure, it is in the public notices, it is on a laminated sheet in four buildings in this city — under which a person requiring maintained authorization may receive it independently of any household determination if that person is in a supported placement administered by the state. The logic is straightforward and humane in intent. A man in a state facility cannot be made to depend on his sister's paperwork. So the

authorization detaches from the household and attaches to the placement, automatically, within seventy-two hours, and it does not lapse, and it cannot be interrupted by a field on a form.

Seventy-two hours. Ninety-one days on one side, seventy-two hours on the other.

She had signed the placement papers on the Friday.

I asked her — and I heard my own voice do it, from some distance away — whether it was reversible.

She said: "You'd know better than me."

And she was right, and I did know, and the answer is that it is reversible in the sense that a person may apply for the discharge of a placement and for the restoration of care to a family member, and that such an application requires an assessment of the home, and the home is a two-room apartment north of the Draw under a lease that has been in dispute since April, and the applicant is a woman working nineteen hours at a laundry with a service notification against her household, and the assessment takes between nine and sixteen months.

It is reversible the way a continuance is fourteen weeks. It is reversible in the same units.

She knew that. I understood, standing there, that she had known it before she signed, that she had done exactly the arithmetic I have just done for you and had done it faster, and that she had chosen the certainty of a permanent loss over the arithmetic of a queue that cleared at eleven to fourteen a day.

She said: "He'll get his medication. On Thursday. Every Thursday."

She said: "That's the whole thing. That's all of it, that's the only thing I had to get."

She said: "I couldn't do it. So somebody who can, does it."

• • •

Now I have to say what I felt, and this is the place where the whole account either holds or comes apart, so I am going to be careful.

I had a thesis. The thesis was that one bad day, correctly arranged, reduces the sanest man alive to lunacy. I had a subject, and the subject had received ninety-one days of exquisitely lawful pressure applied to every load-bearing wall of her life — her housing, her income, her brother's health — and here she was, at my window, on the ninety-first day.

And she was completely sane.

She was more sane than I have ever been. She had held the whole system in her head, all eleven units of it, and she had found the single passage through it, and she had priced the passage honestly and paid it, and she was standing in front of me with a paper cup, describing it in flat correct sentences without one word of self-pity, and there was nothing wrong with her at all.

The thesis was not confirmed. The thesis was refuted, by the subject, in person, using nothing but attention.

And I felt — I want to get this right — I felt the floor of it go.

Because if she can do that, then the corridor was not weather. If a woman with nothing can look at that machine for ninety-one days and find the door, then a man with a car and a folder and an attorney and nineteen years inside the apparatus was not defeated by the apparatus. He was eleven minutes late.

That is the whole of it. That is what I had been building the roof over since April. Not the loss. The loss I could have carried; people carry losses. What I could not carry was that it was *mine* — that there was no mechanism, no machine, no indifferent city, nothing at all between me and the plain fact that a man left at eight-fifteen for a nine-thirty hearing four and a half miles away and did not make it, and that all the rest of it, the thesis and the calendar and the subject and the finding, every word of it, was scaffolding erected around a hole that had one man standing in it.

• • •

She did not break. I need that understood, because there is a version of this in which I say she broke and it would let me keep something.

But something did go out of her, and I saw it go, and I am the only person in Bellhaven who was watching closely enough to see it, which is the single most obscene fact in this account.

It was not her mind. It was the part that comes to a window with the folder already open at the correct page. The part that highlights the field, and draws arrows on a fourth sheet to show you the shape, and says good morning and waits for you to say it back.

She said, at the end, and this was the last thing she ever said to me:

"You were the only one who ever explained any of it. I want you to know that. Everyone else just said it was in review."

Then she said thank you.

She squared the paper cup on the shelf, tap, the way she did with the folder, out of habit, with nothing in her hands worth squaring. And she went out across the marble and through the doors onto Kelder Street, and the rain was doing what it does, and I did not see

her again.

• • •

The queue that day was forty-one deep at the doors. I sat down and said "next, please," and a woman came and sat with a letter about her hours, and I gave her four minutes, and then a man about a change of address, four minutes, and then a boy of nineteen with his mother's paperwork who did not know what any of it meant, and I gave him six, because he was nineteen.

At some point in the afternoon I put my hand in my coat pocket looking for a pen and found the butterscotch.

Eleven weeks in a pocket against a body. The wrapper had gone dark at one corner and the sweet inside had lost its edges and taken on the shape of the pocket, which is what sugar does when it is carried and not eaten. It was still perfectly good. That is the thing about butterscotch. It does not spoil. It only stops being the shape of the thing that was offered.

I held it for a while under the shelf where nobody could see.

Then I put it back in the pocket, and I said: "Next, please."

AE Day 98

The refiled matter was heard on a Wednesday morning in Room 410 of the Vessel Street courthouse, and I left at seven and I was in the corridor at twenty to nine, and I sat on the bench worn pale in two places for fifty minutes with the folder on my knees. Sixteen sheets. Ellen had been right about that; it did look better.

The corridor is thirty-one feet long and the window at the end has wire mesh in it that divides the sky into ninety-six diamonds. In fifty minutes I counted them eleven times, which is one thousand and fifty-six.

The hearing took nineteen minutes.

Nothing went wrong. I want that recorded, because for fourteen weeks I had been carrying an object in my chest with a shape that required something to go wrong, and nothing did. Ellen was thorough. The judge was attentive — genuinely, she read, she asked two questions and both of them were the right questions. The other side did not say anything untrue about me. There was no moment of injustice anywhere in that room.

At the end of it the judge said that on the material before her she was not in a position to vary the arrangement today, that the sixteen sheets demonstrated consistency and that consistency demonstrated over a longer period would carry more weight, that she would direct an assessment, and that the matter would return.

The assessment takes eleven to sixteen weeks. The return date will be assigned.

Nobody found anything against me. Nothing was decided. That is what I had been told in April, on that same bench, by a woman with eighteen minutes, and I had not been able to hear it, because I had needed a verdict — because a verdict is a thing that a man can be angry at, and an interval is not, and I had spent ninety-eight days constructing an entire philosophy of the world rather than accept that what had happened to me was not a decision but a duration.

I came out onto Vessel Street at twenty past ten into the sort of morning Bellhaven gets four times a year, where the cloud comes up off the water and the light goes flat and white and you can see to the end of every street.

The contact centre is on Kelder, eight blocks. I was not going there. I want to be honest about that and I find that I cannot be, entirely: I was walking west and Kelder is west and there is no version of that walk in which I did not know what was at the end of it.

I stopped at the corner across from it at ten to eleven, which is when the eleven o'clock visits arrive.

She came along the far pavement with the transport worker, in a coat I had not seen, which is the detail that does it — not the height, not the hair, the coat, because somebody bought it and it was not me. She was talking. Then she stopped talking and started singing, in the way children sing when they are not performing, badly, loudly, entirely for themselves.

It was the song. She had all of it.

She got the whole way through it and started it again, and the transport worker held the door, and they went inside.

I stood on the corner for a while. Then I went to work.

• • •

I found Ruth on the fire stairs between the second and the third floor at twelve, in the green cardigan.

And I told her.

All of it. The corridor. The clock above the door. Eleven minutes. The four hundred people I ran past. Fourteen weeks and a six-year-old and somebody having to find the words. It came out in the wrong order and it took twenty-five minutes of her forty and I did not stop.

I did not tell her about Dalia. I want to be exact to the last page: I told her about the wound and not about what I did with it, and if you want the measure of me, it is there.

Ruth listened. She listened all the way through, without her phone, without eating, and she did not say she was sorry, and when I finished she was quiet for a bit and then she said:

"Marty. You know what I worked out, about year three?"

I said no.

She said: "That you have to stop looking. Not stop caring — you can't stop that, I've tried. Stop *looking*. Because if you look at all of it, all eleven windows and all the ones outside on the stairs and all the ones who didn't come today, you'll be no good to anybody by Wednesday. So you look at the one in front of you and you don't look past their shoulder. That's the job. That's the whole job."

She said: "Everybody in this building gets there eventually. Some of us it takes years."

And she got the tin out of her cardigan pocket and put a butterscotch on the step between us, and did not look at me while

she did it.

Here is what I understood on that stair, and it is the last thing I understood.

Ruth Mackey is the best person in that building. She is eleventh on the sheet every quarter and she pins it to the corkboard. She remembers your mother in June. She has given away, by my estimate, eleven thousand butterscotches to crying strangers over thirty-one years, at her own expense, from her own drawer.

And she has arrived, by a completely different road, with no corridor and no clock and no bad day of any kind, at the identical position I had to burn my life down to reach: *you cannot afford to look.*

She is not mad. Nobody would say she was mad. She got there by kindness and long service and honest arithmetic, and it is the correct answer, and it is the same answer.

That is when I stopped believing in the bad day. Not on the corner on Kelder. On a concrete stair with a butterscotch on it.

The thing I suffered for is the water. It was always the water. Everyone in this city is already swimming in it, sanely, decently, at a reasonable temperature, and the only difference between them and me is that I got in through the wrong door and came up screaming, and stood in the shallow end announcing my discovery to people who were born there.

• • •

I stayed after the doors closed.

The hall at night is the best thing about that building. They kill the overheads and leave the two lamps at either end, and the marble

goes the colour of milk in tea, and the trough worn down the middle where a hundred and seventy thousand people a year walk the same line is the only thing you can see clearly. The tin ceiling disappears. All two hundred and nine panels, gone, including the one that is not tin.

At nine o'clock I sat down at Window 9 and put in her matter number.

IN REVIEW.

Ninety-eight days.

The correction takes forty seconds. F6, the unit code, enter. It requires no authorization and no memorandum and no supervisor and no explanation, and it would have restored her category, and her category would have restored the lease and the certificate and the hours at the laundry on the Draw, and none of that would have brought her brother back out of a supported placement in eleven to sixteen months, and all of it would have made the following seven weeks of her life materially different in ways that I could list.

I sat with my hand on the terminal.

And I want to put down what was actually in my head, because if I let you assume it you will assume something with dignity in it, some final struggle, and there wasn't one.

What was in my head was this: **that if the correction issues now, someone will eventually ask why it did not issue on the ninth of April.**

That is all. Nobody would ask. There is no aging report that surfaces it, no auditor in that district with the time, and I had a defensible record and two lawful codes and nineteen years of the third-best

closure numbers on the sheet. The risk was as close to zero as a thing gets in this world.

But a man who has spent ninety-eight days building a roof will not put a hole in it to let one person out, and that is not philosophy, and it is not a thesis, and it has nothing to do with one bad day. It is the smallest and most ordinary motive there is. I did not press the key because pressing the key meant that I had not pressed it for ninety-eight days on purpose.

I looked at the screen for a long time.

Then I counted the ceiling — which cannot be seen at night, which I have not needed to see for a very long time, because I know it, eleven across and nineteen deep, and there is a panel over the third window that is not tin — and I got to two hundred and nine.

And here is the room, since we have come this far and there is nobody left to protect.

I was eight. She was not a cruel woman; I want that first, because it is true, and because everything I have written in this book depends on the difference between cruelty and what actually happens. She was ill in a way that had a name she was not given until I was twenty-three. There was a bathroom in a flat on the east side of a city that no longer has that name for that district, and there was a radiator under the window, and she believed, in the medicated periods, when the belief was strongest, that there were things in the building that would take me, and that the only way to be sure was to know exactly where I was.

I do not know how long. That is the thing I have never been able to establish and have stopped trying to. It was not days in the way I said it was for years when I did say it. It was at least one night and I believe it was two, and the reason I do not know is that at some

point I began counting the tiles, which were four inches, in eleven rows of nineteen, and the counting works, that is the entire point of the counting, it takes the time away and gives you nothing back.

And then the medication wore off, or turned over, or whatever the word is — and she came in.

She came in, and she saw, and she made a sound I have never heard another human being make, and she untied me and she held me and she wept, and she was more sorry than anyone has ever been about anything. And she carried me to the kitchen and she made me eggs, and she sat across the table and watched me eat them and could not eat anything herself.

And that is not the injury.

I went to school on the Monday. Nobody asked. There was nothing to see — she had been careful, she was careful about everything, that was the whole shape of her illness. A teacher whose name I could still give you asked me on the Wednesday if I was all right and I said yes, and she said good, and moved on to the register, and she was not doing anything wrong, she had thirty-four of us and forty minutes.

Nobody asked. Not that week and not that year and not once in the forty-three years since.

That is the injury. That is the whole of it. It was never the radiator.

I learned in a bathroom at eight years old that a thing can happen to a person, completely, for two nights, and produce no sound at all outside the room it happens in — that the world has no organ for detecting it, that there is no alarm anywhere in the building, that suffering is not a signal, it is just weather in a room.

And I learned it again, at fifty-one, on the fourth floor of the Vessel Street courthouse, at 9:41, from a young man who was not doing anything wrong.

Twice. Not once.

Forty-three years apart, and I have called the second one *one bad day*, and I have built ninety-eight days of calendar on it, and a thesis, and a subject, and a room to keep the conditions in — because *one bad day* is an event, and an event happens *to* you, and a man that an event happened to is a casualty.

And thirty years of nobody asking is not an event.

It is just a life. It is the ordinary unremarkable life of a man in this city, and there are four hundred thousand of them, and mine has no more shape to it than the traffic on Marrow Street.

• • •

It is 6:12 in the morning and I am sitting on the edge of my bed with my shoes on, which I put on before I was awake.

The correction was not entered last night. I sat with my hand on it until the lamp at the north end went off on its timer, and then I logged out, and I went home.

There is a thing about the calendar that I noticed on the stairs coming down from the hall, and I have been turning it over since, and I am going to write it here and then I am going to go to work.

I set the zero at the wrong day.

The experiment is not the beginning of anything. It is not a discovery and it is not a mechanism and it is not even original — it is a spreadsheet on a departmental drive that some woman started in 2004 because the phone kept ringing. If I had any honesty left I

would tear the calendar up and set the zero on the Tuesday in April at 9:41, and everything since would count forward from there, and I would be, this morning, on Day 101 of a man who was eleven minutes late.

Or I would set it in a bathroom on the east side, in 1983, and I would be somewhere in the fifteen thousands, and the number would be so large and so ordinary that no one, including me, would be able to find anything remarkable in it at all.

The courthouse is filed in my calendar as BE Day 2. Two days before the important thing. The most consequential morning of my life, sitting in the record as a date measured backward from a woman opening a folder at my window.

I know it is wrong. I have known since ten past nine last night.

I am going to leave it.

Downstairs the front door goes, and somebody coughs in the stairwell and does not stop and goes out into the rain still coughing. Through the window the street is the colour of a nickel in a puddle and a bus goes past with the lights on inside and the windows fogged, and there are faces in it, and they are turned toward nothing, and none of them look up.

I have four minutes to give each of sixty-two people today.

I will give the first four to whoever is at the front of the line at half past eight, and I will not look past their shoulder, because Ruth is right, and because it is the job, and because that is what the water is: a whole city of decent people, none of them cruel, none of them mad, each attending perfectly to the one in front of them and to nobody else at all.

If you have got this far and you are waiting for the part where I say I am sorry, I want to be useful to you instead.

Somewhere today a person is going to ask you for something small. Four minutes. A signature. A question answered twice. And you will have an excellent reason, and the reason will be true, and there will be eleven people behind them, and whatever you decide will be defensible in writing.

That is the whole of it. That is all it has ever been.

There is no bad day coming. You are already in it. It is very gentle. It has been going on for some time.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

In *Folie Douce*, there are no drugs,
no conspiracies, and no villains.
Just a city of decent people doing
exactly what they are supposed to do.

When a simple clerical decision quietly
entangles one woman in a web of delays
and lost opportunities, Martin Coyle
begins to see the truth: suffering doesn't
require cruelty. It only requires enough
people with good reasons to look away.

A slow, unsettling novel about attention,
responsibility, and the unnoticed ways
systems erode the soul.

*Most monsters announce themselves.
The most dangerous ones arrive as
reasonable people with excellent
reasons.*

*Open this book and decide which
kind frightens you more.*

